

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

10 December 2021

To a National Spiritual Assembly

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

The Universal House of Justice has recently reviewed the matter of the participation of women in the administrative affairs of your community. It has asked us to convey to you the following.

Since the founding of your community, women have contributed greatly to its diverse spheres of action and played a vital part in the prodigious progress achieved. Sustaining community life has, for the most part, relied on their tireless and sacrificial efforts that extend their influence to the life of the family and help cement the Bahá'í identity of rising generations. Women have arisen as travelling teachers and pioneers, as educators of the young and as tutors, and as initiators and promoters of endeavours for the betterment of society. It has been heart-warming to observe their perseverance with convening women's conferences and their enthusiasm to help organize, supply, and facilitate other gatherings dedicated to teaching and to marking special anniversaries. Indeed, the story of your community's progress is replete with tales of the heroic exploits of women.

Yet, even a cursory review of the service of women on the institutions of the Faith in your community, especially at the regional and national levels, reveals a limited involvement that is out of keeping with this record of devotion by ... Bahá'í women. This long-standing concern became even more evident in the elections of delegates and of members of Local Spiritual Assemblies in places where several localities combined into one and a two-stage election was instituted. But it is most apparent in the membership of your Assembly. For a community such as yours, where an intensive process of community building is releasing powerful transformative forces in many clusters, it would be remiss to allow this situation to persist. It is imperative that you take measures to address it.

As the believers in your community are well aware, applying the principle of the equality of women and men is essential to the regeneration and progress of any nation, the peace of the world, and the advancement of civilization. The statements of 'Abdu'l-Bahá on this matter are clear and emphatic: "Women must advance and fulfil their mission in all departments of life, becoming equal to men." He has further stated: "In the Dispensation of Bahá'u'lláh, women are advancing side by side with men. There is no area or instance where they will lag behind: they have equal rights with men, and will enter, in the future, into all branches of the administration of society. Such will be their elevation that, in every area of endeavour, they will occupy the highest levels in the human world."

You are, then, encouraged to consider, in consultation with the Counsellors, what steps to take to assist the friends across your national community to recognize and overcome whatever obstacles may be impeding the full participation of women in the administration of the Faith. It will be important to first address the matter at the level of consciousness, helping the friends to appreciate the profundity of the principle of the equality of women and men and its ramifications for all aspects of the life of the community. This the dear friends must

not doubt: the subtle influence of habits of thought, culture, and traditions that are inconsonant with the Bahá'í standard endure even among dedicated followers of the Blessed Beauty if there is no conscious and unflagging resolve to counter them. One and all, women and men alike, they are urged to set before their eyes the lofty standard of equality that Bahá'u'lláh has established and to persist in their efforts to attain and express it in every aspect of their individual and collective lives.

What is true for individuals applies similarly to institutions. But they must go even further. They must reflect on how they assign responsibilities to the members of their communities. That they would, when calling on the believers for various services, consider several equally important factors is of course natural, but they cannot overlook the matter of gender or deem it peripheral. In your case, this is particularly important when you are constituting Regional Bahá'í Councils, appointing members of national agencies, and engaging your support staff. Crucially, the preparation of the friends for unit conventions and of the delegates for National Conventions needs to ensure that they are able to carry out their duties as electors wholly conscious of the necessity of the full involvement of women in the administrative affairs of the Faith. When the House of Justice addressed the matter of Bahá'í elections in its letter of 25 March 2007, it reiterated the qualities "of unquestioned loyalty, of selfless devotion, of a well-trained mind, of recognized ability and mature experience" specified by the Guardian as necessary for those believers whom an elector seeks to choose as members of the institutions. But it emphasized further that "from among the pool of those whom the elector believes to be qualified to serve, selection should be made with due consideration given to such other factors as age distribution, diversity, and gender." Having all these requisites in mind will help the friends fulfil what was the express wish of the Guardian, that "the Assembly should be representative of the choicest and most varied and capable elements in every Bahá'í community."

As you certainly appreciate, all actions you take in this important matter need to be tempered by wisdom and dignity; nonetheless, they must not be delayed. You can be confident that when the application of the principle of equality between women and men is expressed in the unfettered service of women on the institutions and agencies of the Faith, the victories of your community will multiply, and it will exert an even greater transforming influence on the life of your society. The House of Justice would appreciate your keeping it informed of your actions and their related results. It will supplicate the Blessed Beauty in the Holy Shrines that He may abundantly bless and confirm every effort you and the friends in your community make.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]